

Research Statement

I have been fascinated by how much we can learn about firms by looking beyond traditional financial measures. What executives say, who they are connected to, and how firms organize their decision makers can reveal information. This perspective has shaped my research in corporate finance and the questions I plan to pursue going forward. Broadly, I am interested in how information, incentives, uncertainty, and organizational structures shape corporate decisions and executive behavior, with particular interests in corporate governance, executive communication, disclosure, and information transmission. I am drawn to questions that are academically important but also relevant to those who make and interpret corporate decisions, including managers, boards, investors, analysts, and regulators.

My approach to research begins where an important mechanism- such as executive behavior, information transmission, or internal organizational structure- is difficult to observe directly. I then look for data and empirical settings that make that mechanism measurable and allow competing explanations to be distinguished. My research has therefore drawn on textual analysis, executive and director data, corporate networks, using empirical methods appropriate to each question. Methodological rigor is essential to my work, but the method is a means to an end: my objective is to provide convincing evidence on questions that deepen our understanding of how firms and their decision makers behave.

My doctoral research has developed this philosophy across several settings. My job market paper, co-authored with Professor Ali Akyol, examines whether CEOs reveal information about their circumstances through the way they communicate before forced turnover. Using textual analysis of 45,438 CEO-quarter earnings conference calls between 2010 and 2018, including 224 forced turnovers, we find that CEOs approaching forced dismissal exhibit distinctive linguistic patterns relative to retained CEOs. These differences become substantially stronger as turnover approaches and are not observed among CFOs at the same firms. Beyond the specific setting of CEO turnover, this project has shaped how I think about corporate disclosure and executive behavior: communication can reveal information about decision makers before an observable governance event occurs. This perspective creates opportunities to study corporate communication not only as a mechanism for conveying financial information, but also as a window into executive incentives, behavior, and uncertainty. The paper has been presented at the 2026 Financial Management Association European Conference, and we are currently revising it following a reject-and-resubmit decision from the *Journal of Banking & Finance*.

The second working paper co-authored with Professor Ali Akyol investigates board interlocks using the widespread withdrawal of earnings guidance during COVID-19 to study information transmission between connected firms. We find that smaller firms are more likely to withdraw guidance shortly after a larger, board-interlocked firm does so, particularly when the connection operates through an audit committee member with relevant financial expertise. This project has led me to think about corporate networks not simply as connections between firms, but as channels through which economically meaningful information can travel. It has also generated broader questions that I intend to pursue about who carries information within corporate networks, what determines the direction of information flows, and how uncertainty changes the importance of these connections for corporate disclosure and decision-making.

A related part of my research examines organizational structure within the firm. My work on senior vice presidents asks when additional layers of senior management represent costly organizational complexity and when they provide valuable managerial capacity. Using U.S. public-firm data from 2005 to 2024, I find that excess VP employment is associated with lower firm value on average, but this relationship reverses in large, complex organizations and during periods of economic stress. What interests me particularly about this result is that the same organizational structure can represent costly bureaucracy in one setting and valuable coordination capacity in another. This project has broadened my interest toward questions about executive-team composition, managerial layers, organizational complexity, and how firms adapt their internal structures to changing economic conditions.

In the near term, my research priorities are to complete and publish these projects and develop the next generation of work that grows from them. My immediate priority is the revision of my job market paper for the *Journal of Banking & Finance*, alongside advancing the board-interlock and VP projects toward submission. At the same time, I will also begin a new project with Professors Ali Akyol and Kee-Hong Bae of York University that extends my work on language style to a different corporate context. We are currently applying for an Insight Grant from the Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council of Canada (SSHRC), one of Canada's federal research funding agencies, to support this project. Together, these projects provide both an active publication pipeline and a foundation for developing new questions beyond my dissertation.

Over the next five years, I plan to broaden my research agenda beyond the specific settings of my dissertation while remaining grounded in corporate finance. I am particularly interested in how executives and firms respond to changes in their information environment, market uncertainty, and governance conditions. I also plan to explore new textual, behavioral, and executive-level data to better understand managerial decision-making and corporate behavior. These directions will allow me to examine how information and executive behavior ultimately influence disclosure choices, corporate decisions, and firm outcomes.

An important goal of this agenda is to produce research that contributes to academic debates while remaining relevant to financial decision makers. Understanding whether executive communication contains signals of future governance events matters to boards, analysts, and investors. Understanding how information moves through corporate networks can inform how we think about disclosure decisions and the role of directors. Understanding when managerial layers create or destroy value has implications for executives and boards designing organizations, particularly during periods of uncertainty. I therefore view practical relevance and academic contribution as complementary rather than competing objectives. My goal is to publish this work in high-quality peer-reviewed finance journals appropriate to the contribution of each project and to develop a sustained research pipeline that contributes to the corporate finance, governance, disclosure, and executive-behavior literatures.

Ultimately, the common motivation behind my research is a desire to understand aspects of firms that are economically important but not always directly visible in conventional financial data. My work to date has approached this challenge through executive language, corporate networks, disclosure decisions, and senior-management structure. Going forward, I intend to expand both the questions and the settings I study while maintaining this underlying approach. Five years from now, I aim to have established a recognizable research agenda in corporate finance that combines important questions, creative measurement, and rigorous empirical analysis to better understand how information, uncertainty, and the people within firms shape corporate decisions and outcomes.